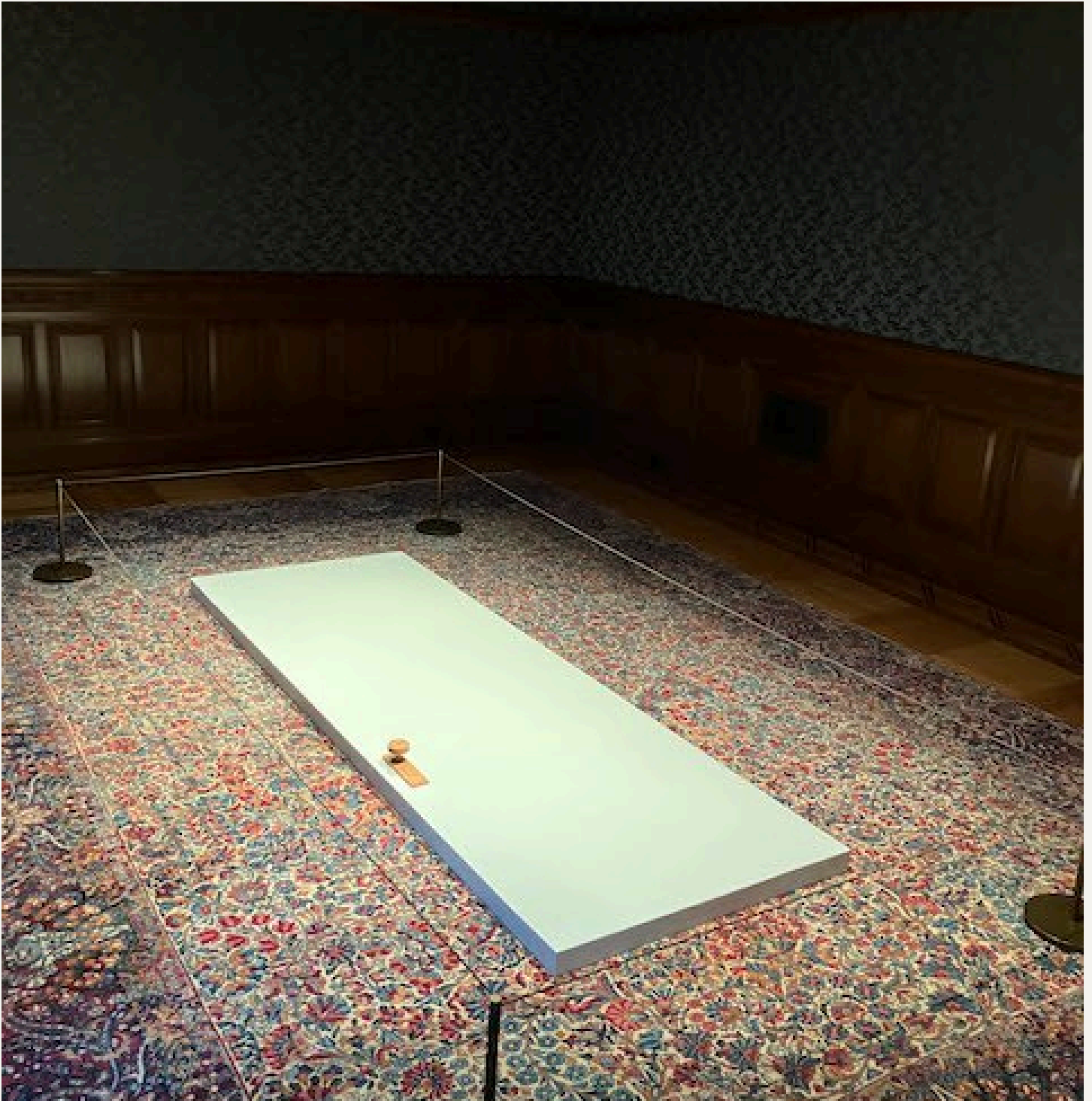


OBJECTS / 2025 / DRIEHAUS MUSEUM, CHICAGO

Palimpsest

Industry of the Ordinary, Driehaus Museum



A Driehaus Museum doorknob, 3D scanned and recast in clay taken from the Chicago River.

THE WORK

After the Great Chicago Fire of 1871, new buildings had to be brick or stone, and builders dug clay from the bed of the Chicago River to make the bricks that rebuilt the Nickerson Mansion, now the Driehaus Museum. Industry of the Ordinary took a brass doorknob from one of the doors that separates the family rooms from the servants' quarters and remade it in Chicago River clay, laid on a prone facsimile of its door: a trapdoor between upstairs and downstairs, and a work about the labor that grand houses make invisible.

THE MATERIAL QUESTION

An exact copy of a museum object, in a material that fights precision. The original could not leave its door, and river clay shrinks and moves as it dries and fires, so the duplicate had to come from data, then survive the kiln still reading as that particular knob.

THE MAKING

We 3D scanned the knob and its plate in place at the museum, cleaned the scan into a model, and split it into molds for the knob and the backplate. Test pieces were pressed and fired [at more than one temperature] to dial in shrinkage and color. [Confirm the process: scanning, modeling, molds, pressing and firing. Who dug and prepared the clay?]

IN PLACE

Shown in Materialities at the Driehaus Museum from February 7 to April 27, 2025. The artists thanked Matthew Groves, H Schenck, Ally Reza and Ben Stagl. It was our second project with Industry of the Ordinary, after the cast glass Apple.

DETAILS

Year

2025

Location

Driehaus Museum, Chicago

Category

Objects

Materials

Chicago River clay, painted wood

CREDITS

Artists: Industry of the Ordinary

Exhibition: Materialities, curated by Giovanni Aloï Driehaus Museum

STUDIO

ChiLab Studio

Chicago, Illinois

Established 2013



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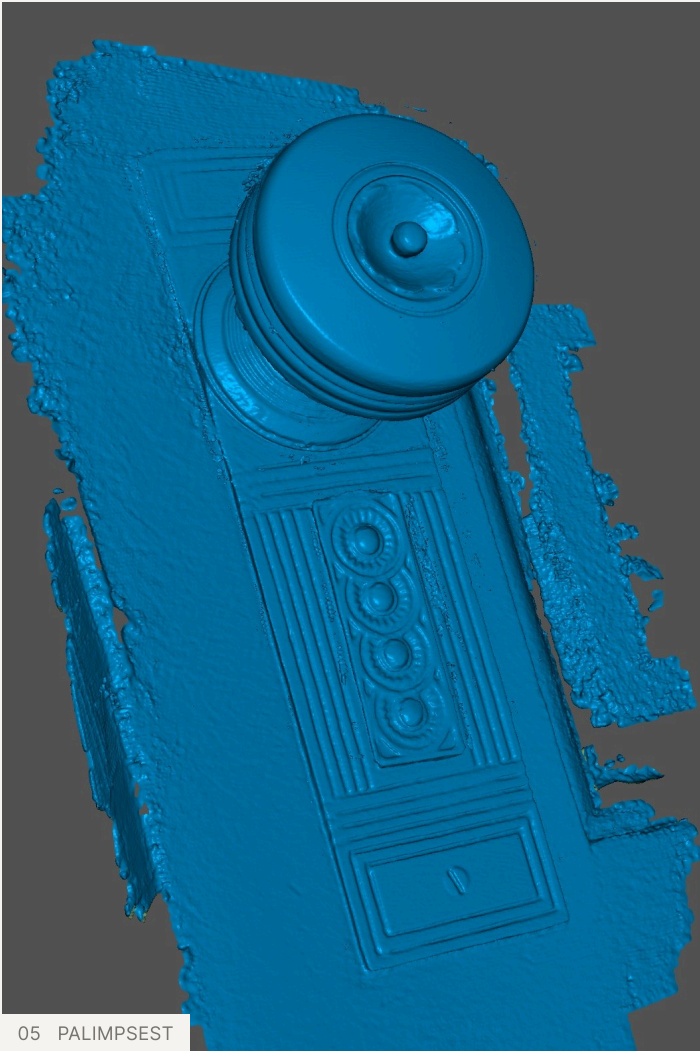
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04 PALIMPSEST



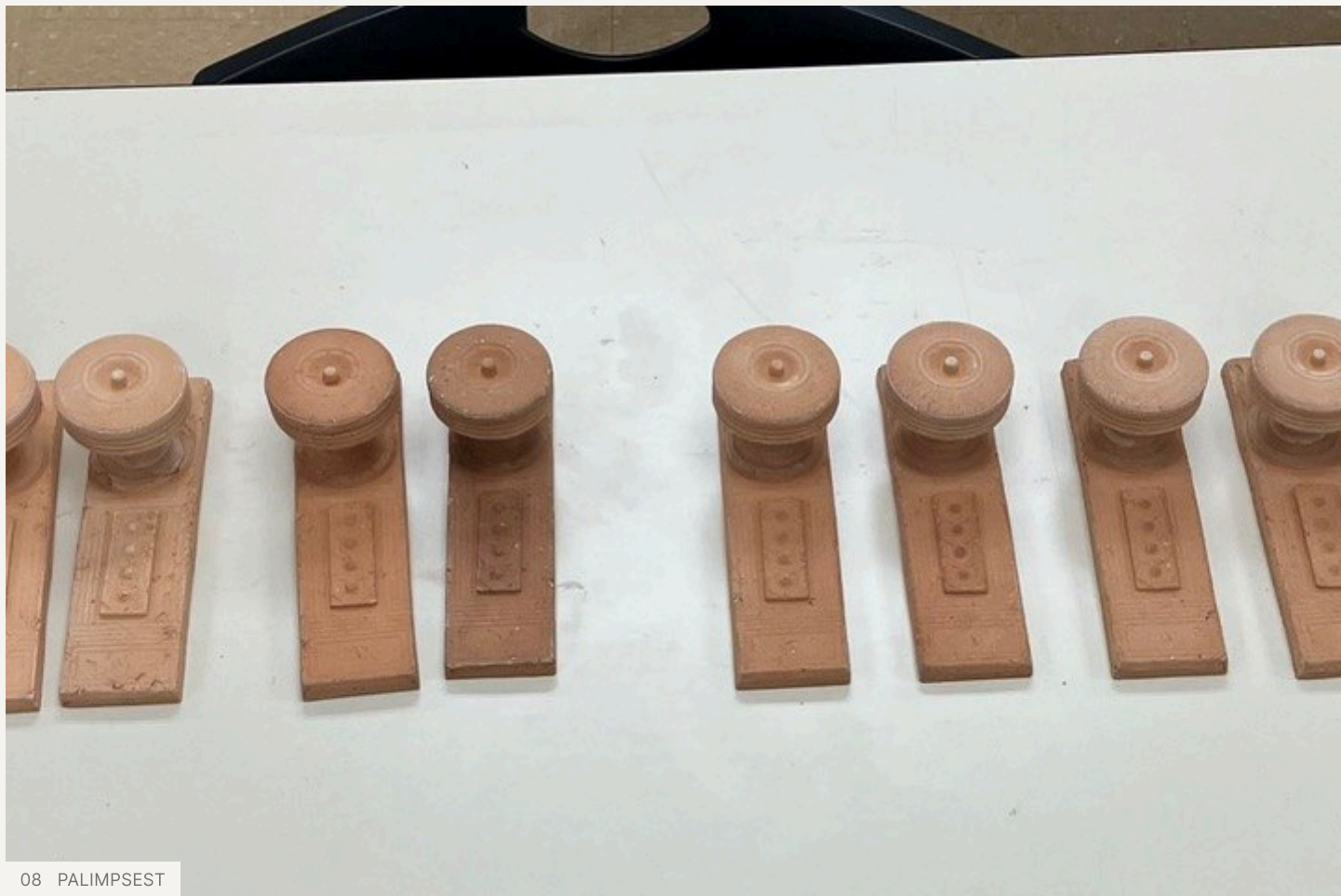
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07 PALIMPSEST



08 PALIMPSEST

Bring us a drawing, a model, or a hunch.

THE STUDIO

Specialty material projects for architecture, interior design, public art, and the fine arts.

ChiLab Studio, Chicago, Illinois. Established 2013.

WHAT WE DO

Metal casting

Glass

Finishes

Digital fabrication

Metal fabrication

Restoration

Project management

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